the National Conference, a secular and progressive body with policies where Islamic theology gave way to more pressing issues such as land reforms. In 1941, following the announcement of the Pakistan Resolution in Lahore, many Muslims in the state, disgruntled with Abdullah and the secular nature of the National Conference, convinced the Mirwaiz to resurrect the Muslim Conference. The newly resurrected organisation became the trump card for both Mohammed Ali Jinnah and the Muslim League. The National Conference, with its secular agenda, and the Muslim Conference, with its rabidly communal agenda, spearheaded the political struggle against the Maharaja's rule.

Within 10 years, the political opposition to the Maharaja's rule was legally mobilised under two different ideological strains. The British had succeeded in gradually eroding the omniscience of the Maharaja and had ensured the institutionalisation of a process that caused him continuous problems and ultimately unseated him.

The 1934 Constitution lasted only five years. A relentless campaign of protest by the politicians from the mobilised Muslim majority forced the Maharaja to scrap the existing constitution in favour of a new one, in 1939. The crown of thorns that sat on the Maharaja's head never gave him a moment of peace since the 1930 Round Table Conference took place in London.

The British Prepare to Snatch Gilgit

One of the reasons behind the introduction of the constitution in 1934 was to keep the Maharaja preoccupied with political changes in the valley, and to deflect his attention away from the state's northern borders. During this period, in neighbouring Sinkiang, Sheng-ts'ai, a Chinese warlord, had taken control over most of the region.[17] This development was dangerous for the Indian Government because Sheng-ts'ai was in close contact with the Soviets. There was a high chance that Sinkiang would become a Soviet puppet state or be completely absorbed into the Soviet Union.